Getting Started with Claude: Desktop App, VS Code and Terminal

Most of you should start with the desktop app: it is the quickest install, needs no terminal, and covers chat, longer agentic tasks and coding in one window. VS Code and the terminal are optional routes for those who already work in code editors or command lines.

Which option should I pick?

	Desktop app	VS Code	Terminal
Best for	Everyone, first-time users	Editing code with Claude beside your files	Command-line users, remote machines
Looks like	App with Chat, Cowork and Code tabs	Side panel inside VS Code	Text prompt in a terminal
Install	Download and run	VS Code plus one extension	One command, then log in
Terminal needed	No	No	Yes
Account	Free for Chat, paid for Code	Paid plan or Console	Paid plan or Console

All three can be installed side by side on the same laptop and use the same Claude account.

Option 1: the Claude desktop app (recommended start)

The desktop app runs on macOS 11 (Big Sur) or later and Windows 10 or later, and has three tabs: **Chat** (general conversation, no file access), **Cowork** (an agent that works on tasks in the background) and **Code** (works directly on files in a folder on your computer). (Install guide, Code tab quickstart)

Install

1. Go to claude.ai/download and download the version for your computer.
2. **Mac:** open the downloaded file, drag Claude into your Applications folder, then launch it from there.

3. **Windows:** run the downloaded installer, then launch Claude from the Start menu. On a Windows ARM laptop (for example a Snapdragon Surface), use the ARM64 installer listed on the desktop docs page.
4. Sign in with your Claude account (create one for free if you do not have it).

First session in the Code tab

1. Click the **Code** tab at the top centre. If it asks you to upgrade, you need a paid plan first.
2. Choose **Local**, click **Select folder**, and pick a folder holding your coursework files or a small project.
3. Pick a model from the dropdown next to the send button, type a request such as "summarise what is in this folder", and press Enter.
4. Check the permission mode next to the send button. In **Manual** mode Claude shows each proposed change and waits for you to accept or reject it; this is the safest setting while you are learning.

The app already includes Claude Code, so you do not need to install anything else or open a terminal to use the Code tab.

Tip: type `@filename` in the prompt box to point Claude at a specific file, and use the stop button if it heads in the wrong direction.

Option 2: Claude in VS Code

The Claude Code extension puts a Claude panel inside Visual Studio Code, next to your files, with side-by-side diffs of every change it proposes. It needs VS Code 1.94.0 or later and a paid Claude plan or a Claude Console account. (Extension docs)

Step 1: install VS Code

Mac

1. Download VS Code from code.visualstudio.com/download. Choose Apple silicon for M1/M2/M3/M4 Macs, Intel for older ones, or Universal if unsure.
2. Open the downloaded `.dmg` and drag Visual Studio Code into your Applications folder.
3. Launch it from Applications.

Windows

1. From the same download page, choose the **User Installer** (it does not need administrator rights).
2. Run the installer (`VSCodeUserSetup-...exe`) and accept the defaults.

3. Restart any open terminal windows afterwards. (VS Code on Mac, VS Code on Windows)

Step 2: add the Claude Code extension

1. In VS Code, open the Extensions view with `Cmd+Shift+X` (Mac) or `Ctrl+Shift+X` (Windows).
2. Search for "Claude Code" (publisher: Anthropic) and click **Install**.
3. If the extension does not appear, restart VS Code or run **Developer: Reload Window** from the Command Palette (`Cmd/Ctrl+Shift+P`).

Step 3: open a folder, sign in, ask

1. Use **File > Open Folder** and choose your coursework or project folder.
2. Click the Spark icon at the top right of the editor (it appears once a file is open), or click **Claude Code** in the bottom-right status bar.
3. On first use click **Sign in** and finish authorising in your browser.
4. Type a request in the prompt box. Claude sees any text you have selected; press `Option+K` (Mac) or `Alt+K` (Windows) to also add an @-mention of that file and line range.
5. In Manual mode Claude shows a before/after diff and asks you to accept or reject each edit.

Tip: switch to **Plan** mode (or type `/plan`) to have Claude lay out what it intends to do and wait for your approval before touching any file.

Option 3: Claude Code in the terminal (CLI)

The command-line version runs in a text window and is the most flexible route, but also the least forgiving for first-time terminal users. It needs a paid Claude plan or a Claude Console account. (Quickstart)

Step 1: open a terminal

- **Mac:** press `Cmd+Space` , type "Terminal" and press Enter.
- **Windows:** open the Start menu, type "PowerShell" and open **Windows PowerShell**. The prompt starts with `PS C:\` .

Step 2: install Claude Code

Paste the command for your system and press Enter. It prints no progress while it downloads, so wait for the prompt to return.

Mac

```
curl -fsSL https://claude.ai/install.sh | bash
```

Windows (PowerShell)

```
irm https://claude.ai/install.ps1 | iex
```

On Windows, Git for Windows is recommended so Claude Code can use its Bash tool; without it Claude Code falls back to PowerShell.

Step 3: check it worked

Close the terminal, open a new one, and run:

```
claude --version
```

A version number means success. "command not found" or "not recognized" means the install folder is not on your PATH yet; see the installation troubleshooting page.

Step 4: start a session

Move into the folder you want Claude to work on, then start it:

```
cd path/to/your/folder
claude
```

On first use Claude Code asks you to log in; follow the prompts to authorise in your browser. After that you will not need to log in again.

Commands worth knowing

Command	What it does
`/help`	Lists the available commands
`/clear`	Clears the conversation and starts fresh
`/resume`	Continues a previous conversation
`/login`	Switches account or re-authenticates
`/exit`	Quits Claude Code
`Shift+Tab`	Cycles the permission mode, so Claude asks before it edits

Note: if you also use VS Code, the extension bundles its own copy of Claude Code for the chat panel, but typing `claude` in VS Code's built-in terminal still needs this separate install.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Fix
Desktop: Code tab asks you to upgrade	Claude Code needs a paid plan; subscribe, then reopen the app
Desktop: Code tab asks you to sign in online	Finish the sign-in in your browser, then restart the app
Desktop: 403 error in the Code tab	See authentication troubleshooting
VS Code: extension installed but not showing	Restart VS Code, or run Developer: Reload Window
VS Code: Spark icon missing	It only shows with a file open; click Claude Code in the bottom-right status bar
VS Code: "Not logged in · Please run /login"	Reopen the panel for the sign-in screen, or reload the window
VS Code: `code .` not found	Mac: Command Palette, then "Shell Command: Install 'code' command in PATH". Windows: restart the console
Terminal: `claude` not found	Open a new terminal; if it persists, follow the PATH fix
Windows: `The token '&&' is not a valid statement separator`	You pasted the CMD command into PowerShell; use the PowerShell one
Windows: `'irm' is not recognized`	You are in CMD; open PowerShell instead
Terminal: install fails with `403` or `syntax error near unexpected token '<'`	See Troubleshoot installation

Sources

All pages opened on 11 Oct 2026; instructions may change as the apps update.

- Install Claude for Desktop
- Get started with the desktop app

- Claude Code quickstart
- Use Claude Code in VS Code
- VS Code on macOS and on Windows